

The Static Between Breaths

The rain didn't so much fall in Aethelburg as it congealed. It was a greasy, chemical slick that slid down the permaglass of my hab-unit window, a mournful squeak against the filth. It blurred the neon torment of the city into a watercolor of bleeding sores. Red from the Kanto-Corp geisha hologram across the chasm, her smile a hundred feet wide and utterly dead. Blue from the endless, silent drizzle of pharm-ads promising serenity in a caplet. A sickly, sulfurous yellow from the atmospheric processors struggling in the Undersump. I was watching the colors swim, my brain too sluggish to process them as anything but abstract pain, when the buzz came.

It was a high-frequency whine that cut right through the cotton-wool fog of my Syn-Numb hangover, a dentist's drill boring directly into my mastoid. It wasn't the door chime—that had been broken for months, shorted out by the ceaseless damp. It was the private comm, the one hardwired directly into the bone behind my ear, the one I'd paid a back-alley ripperdoc named 'Twitch' a fuck-ton of creds to install and encrypt. Twitch had lived up to his name, his cybernetic fingers spasming as he worked, but the tech was solid. This line was reserved for jobs. The kind of jobs that paid enough to make you forget why you needed to forget in the first place.

I grunted, a sound scraped raw from my throat, and rolled off the stained mattress. It wasn't just stained; it was a geographical map of my own decay. The floor was cold steel, littered with the detritus of a man circling the drain: empty nutrient paste tubes, their metallic taste still lingering in the air; the glint of silver ampules, the spent cartridges of my Syn-Numb prescription; and a single, pathetic synth-leather glove, its partner lost to some forgotten blackout. My head was a sack of wet sand with broken glass mixed in. Fucking Tuesdays.

"Jax," I croaked, the word tearing at my vocal cords. The comm chirped softly, a bird in my skull, authenticating my voiceprint. A wall panel, previously the color of dead fish, flickered to life. It displayed a single, austere sigil: a stylized silver raven, wings unfurled, its eye a single point of red light. Clean. Corporate. Or at least aspiring to be. Underneath, a line of stark, white text.

CLIENT: V.S.

JOB: Retrieval.

TARGET: Stolen Locket (Memory-Class, Encrypted).

PAYMENT: 50,000 U-Creds.

Fifty thousand. My breath hitched. That wasn't just a month of blissful emptiness. That was... an option. A down payment on a transport ticket to an off-world colony. A full system flush from a legitimate clinic, not some Sump-dwelling sawbones. Enough to maybe, just maybe, replace the glitching optical implant that made everything in my right periphery shimmer like a heat haze over asphalt. It was a choice between dying slowly and living broken. The usual, but with higher stakes.

"Details," I mumbled, pinching the bridge of my nose. The headache was a physical presence, a little bastard with an ice pick chipping away at the inside of my skull.

The sigil dissolved, replaced by a data-packet. I let it stream, the information trickling into my consciousness not as words, but as a cascade of intended meaning—a residual perk of my old life, the ghost in my machine.

The item is a memory-locket. Not corporate issue. Private collection. Platinum filigree, serpentine design. Inset with a single shard of polished obsidian. Small. Easy to conceal. Dimensions: 4cm x 3cm. Contains three partitioned memories, heavily encrypted with a custom algorithm. Sentimental value, client claims.

A flicker. A phantom sensation. For a split second, the data-stream felt... familiar. Not the content, but the texture of the encryption. Layered, defensive, almost paranoid. It reminded me of the work we did at Omni-Solutions, walling off the consciousnesses of our high-value clients from psychic intrusion. My own work. I pushed the thought down. It was a ghost, a data-echo. Nothing more.

Client insists on discretion. No corporate entanglements. No official channels. The transaction must be clean.

Yeah, right. "Sentimental value" was code for "blackmail material" or "stolen IP." Fifty grand wasn't a price for sentiment. It was a price for silence, and "discretion" was code for "don't leave any witnesses." V.S. The initials meant nothing. Could be some high-level corporate exec with a dirty secret. Could be a jilted lover from the Spire, the glittering needle where the city's elite lived above the clouds and the filth. Didn't matter. Their creds were good.

Target is a low-life data-runner and fence. Calls himself 'Silas'. Known to operate in the Gutter-Flow market, down in the Sump. Last known ping was a pleasure-den called 'The Gilded Cage'. He has a weakness for chromed flesh and cheap thrills.

The Gilded Cage. My stomach clenched, a fist of ice. A place where you could buy anything, or anyone, for an hour. A meat market where flesh and chrome were interchangeable commodities. Not my scene. Not anymore. It was too loud, too full of other people's wants, a symphony of desperation that scraped at the edges of my Syn-Numb shield.

"Fine," I subvocalized the acceptance command. A wave of nausea rolled through me. It wasn't just the hangover. It was the feeling of plugging back in, even this slightly.

The raven sigil flashed once—*CONTRACT ACCEPTED*—and the panel went dark. Fifty thousand U-Creds. The first half hit my account a second later with a soft, satisfying chime that echoed in the silence of my squalid little box. Twenty-five K. The Numb was already singing its sweet, silent song in my veins, a siren call to oblivion.

I stumbled to the refresher, splashing murky, recycled water on my face. The face that looked back from the mirror was a stranger's. Gaunt, with dark pits for eyes that held the flat, affectless stare of a malfunctioning android. A web of faint, silvery scars traced a line from my temple to my jaw, a souvenir from my "Expedited Early Retirement" from Omni-Solutions. They called me an Empath back then. A marketing-friendly term for a psychic sponge. My job was to plug into raw data streams—financial reports, consumer trends, intercepted comms—and *feel* the patterns. To translate the cold, hard binary into gut feelings, into actionable human insight. *"The market feels skittish about the protein merger, there's an undercurrent of panic."* *"This new product line... it evokes a feeling of manufactured nostalgia, it'll test well with Gen-C."*

I was a human API. They'd run a million lifetimes of joy, terror, and soul-crushing boredom through my synapses until the wires started to fray. Until I'd wake up screaming from a nightmare about a stock market crash I'd only ever experienced as data. Until I couldn't tell the synthetic emotions of a focus group from my own grief.

That's when I found the Syn-Numb. A beautiful, elegant little hack. An illegal neuro-suppressant that dampened the signal. It turned the roar of the data-sphere into a gentle hum. It turned my own screaming psyche into a distant whisper. Now, I was just Jax. A retriever. A glorified lost-and-found clerk for the city's scum. Cleaner work, in its own fucked-up way.

I pulled on a reinforced long-coat, its syn-leather cracked and worn, the collar high enough to hide the scars. I checked the charge on my kinetic pistol—a nasty, brutish piece of work that fired a solid slug of compressed polymers. It wasn't elegant, but it made a definitive fucking hole in things. I slotted a fresh, gleaming ampule of Numb into the auto-injector on my wrist. I didn't press the button. Not yet. This one was for later. For the pain. Or for the feelings. Same thing, really.

Stepping out of my hab-unit was like stepping into the city's open, weeping guts. The air was a thick cocktail of ozone from the mag-trains, the cloying sweetness of frying synth-noodles, and the damp, metallic tang of desperation. Hover-cars sliced through the perpetual twilight above, their engines a distant whine that sounded like weeping. Down here, on the mag-walks, it was a river of bodies. Grifters with twitching eyes, wage-slaves with the gray pallor of the cubicle-bound, chrome-junkies with flickering optics and jerky movements, all flowing with the same hurried, haunted pace toward somewhere they didn't want to be.

The Sump was a vertical descent, a journey into the city's bowels. The elevators weren't gleaming pods like in the Spire; they were rusty freight cages that smelled of piss, fear, and cheap stimulants. I crowded in with a half-dozen others. A woman with a baby whose cries were unnervingly silent, its eyes a milky blue. A massive dockworker, his vat-grown muscles bulging beneath a grime-stained shirt. Two synth-goths with identical black lips and vacant expressions. No one spoke. No one made eye contact. With each level we dropped, the neon got dimmer, the air got thicker, and the faces got harder. This was where the city flushed its refuse, human and otherwise.

The Gutter-Flow market was a chaotic sprawl under the city's massive, sweating coolant pipes. They dripped a steady, rhythmic torture onto the corrugated iron roofs—*plink... plonk... plink*—a maddening water clock counting down to nothing. Stalls made of scrap metal and scavenged plastic were piled high with everything and nothing. Stolen cybernetics still crusted with bio-matter, counterfeit food rations, pirated sim-dreams, and weapons of every conceivable caliber. The vendors were predators, their eyes scanning the crowds for weakness, for a flicker of need. The air tasted of rust and decay.

The Gilded Cage wasn't hard to find. Amidst the chaos and rust, it was the only place with a clean door. A slab of polished, unmarked chrome set into a reinforced wall. It was guarded by a mountain of muscle and metal, a bouncer whose arms were thick as my torso, rippling with subcutaneous hydraulics. His face was a placid, cybernetic mask, the kind with no expressions programmed in, but his one good human eye—a startlingly clear, brown eye—sized me up with a cold, professional disinterest.

"Business," I said, my voice flat. I held up my left hand, palm-out. My cred-chip glowed faintly under the skin, a silent promise of payment.

The bouncer grunted, a sound like grinding stones. A red scanner beam shot from his forehead, washing over me, cataloging, assessing. It lingered on my pistol, on the injector on my wrist. He wasn't just checking for weapons; he was checking my net worth, my criminal record, my bio-signs. A violation I was long past caring about. The light blinked green. He gave a slight, almost imperceptible nod. The chrome door slid open with a heavy, expensive-sounding pneumatic hiss.

The air that hit me was a physical blow. A wall of sound and perfume and heat. Sweet, cloying synth-smoke, the animal sweat of a hundred packed-in bodies, and the bass-heavy, joyless throb of some industrial beat that vibrated up through the soles of my boots. The light was low, cast in shades of lurid crimson and deep, bruised purple. Booths lined the walls, veiled with shimmering, semi-transparent holo-curtains. They flickered with abstract patterns, but you could see the silhouettes moving behind them—some locked in slow, sensual embraces; some hunched over tables in tense, silent transactions; some just staring into the middle distance, lost in whatever sim-dream or chemical haze they'd paid for.

This wasn't a place for finding people. It was a place for getting lost. For dissolving. And somewhere in this shithole, a data-thief named Silas was holding onto a memory that was worth more than my life. I felt a familiar tremor at the edge of my awareness, the psychic noise of so many minds in one space, a cacophony of lust, greed, and despair. It was like sandpaper on my nerves.

My thumb found the button on my wrist injector. I pushed it.

The plunger sank home with a soft click. The Syn-Numb hit my bloodstream like a wave of cool water, a spreading numbness that started in my arm and radiated outward. The thumping bass receded, the sharp edges of the light softened, the psychic chatter of the crowd dissolved into a low, meaningless

hum. The static was back. My shield. My peace. The world was still a piece of shit, but now it was a piece of shit behind a thick pane of glass.

Better.

I pushed my way through the throng towards the bar, a long counter of imitation onyx tended by a chrome-armed 'tender with four limbs, moving with an insectoid grace as he mixed iridescent cocktails. I needed to start asking questions. And in a place like this, information flowed from the same source as the booze. I leaned against the sticky bar, the cool of the Numb settling deep in my bones, and waited for the 'tender to notice me. The hunt was on.

The four-armed bartender glided over, its polished chrome face a blank slate reflecting the lurid club lights. "Quench?" its voice was a synthesized, genderless purr.

"Information," I said, sliding a hundred-cred chit across the sticky bar. "Looking for a data-runner. Calls himself Silas. Scrawny, nervous type. Likes to flash chrome he can't afford."

The bartender's four hands didn't stop their work—one polishing a glass, one mixing a drink, one taking an order from a woman with glowing veins down the bar. The fourth hand, the one closest to me, swept the chit off the counter and into a slot on its torso without breaking rhythm. Its head tilted a fraction of a degree. "The Cage has many guests. Privacy is our primary product."

"His privacy is fucking with my product," I growled, letting a little of the Sump-rat edge into my voice. I slid another chit across the bar. Two hundred. "Fifty-thousand-cred product."

The red optical sensor in the 'tender's face glowed a little brighter as it scanned the chit and, presumably, my sincerity. The name of the game. You don't mention the job, you mention the value. Money is the only language these things are programmed to understand.

"High-stakes data-deck," the synth-voice purred, a little more cooperative now. "Back room. Veil-cove seven. He's on a losing streak. Unwise for a man in his position." The 'tender's head swiveled away, its attention already gone. Transaction complete.

I pushed off the bar and moved deeper into the den. The crowd thickened here, the bodies pressing in. The Syn-Numb was doing its job, keeping the psychic pressure at bay, but I could still feel the heat, smell the desperation. Veil-cove seven was at the back, in a recessed area where the music was slightly more muted and the air crackled with the faint ozone smell of overloaded processors.

The curtain to the cove was a shimmering field of black and silver static. I didn't bother announcing myself. I just pushed through.

The space inside was small, barely a closet. A circular table dominated the room, its surface a shifting holographic display of cascading code. Three figures were hunched over it. Two were heavies, their faces grim, cheap cybernetics bolted onto their skulls. The third, sitting opposite them, was my target. Silas.

He was just as the file described. Scrawny, with a cheap synth-leather jacket and a face slick with sweat. His eyes, wide and bloodshot, were fixed on the data-stream. A neural-interface cable ran from a port at his temple directly into the table. He was gambling with raw data, trying to crack encryption strings faster than his opponents. A fool's game. His only notable chrome was a single, elegantly crafted silver hand, which was currently twitching over the tabletop, the fingers spasming uncontrollably. A classic sign of a black-market implant rejecting its new host.

The locket was on the table, next to a dwindling pile of cred-chits. Platinum filigree glinting in the gloom. His ante. He was betting everything.

The two heavies looked up as I entered, their hands moving instinctively toward the pistols holstered under their jackets.

I ignored them and looked at Silas. "You and I need to talk."

Silas didn't look up, his focus absolute. "Fuck off. I'm in the middle of a run."

"Your run's over," I said, my voice flat. I drew my kinetic pistol. It didn't make a sound, but it was heavy and ugly and real. The heavies froze, their expressions shifting from aggression to calculation. They were hired muscle, not loyalists. They were weighing the odds.

"That locket," I said, nodding my chin toward it. "It's mine now. You can walk away. Or you can be carried away. Your choice."

Finally, Silas's head snapped up. His eyes, dilated and manic, fixed on me. And then a slow, greasy smile spread across his face. A smile of recognition. My blood ran cold. It wasn't me he recognized. It was something *about* me.

"Holy shit," he breathed, a laugh rattling in his chest. "Jax. The Omni-Solutions ghost. I'll be damned." He leaned back, the neural-cable pulling taut. "They said you were fried. A complete wipe."

The Syn-Numb fog in my head thinned, pierced by a shard of ice. "You don't know me."

"Don't I?" Silas's twitching silver hand gestured at the locket. "I ran the outer shell of this thing. The encryption... it's Omni-spec. The really high-end, mind-killer shit. I thought I'd hit the jackpot, some exec's dirty laundry. But it's not. It's a goddamn soul-trap. And the signature on the core partition... it

matches the public profile of their lead Empath before he had his little 'accident'." Silas's smile was a predatory slash. "That's you, isn't it, you poor bastard? They didn't just fire you. They fucking *gutted* you."

The room tilted. The air was thick. The two heavies were forgotten. The thumping music from outside was the beat of my own terrified heart.

The item contains partitioned memories...

The encryption feels familiar...

"What's in it?" I asked, my voice a whisper. My pistol didn't waver, but my hand was slick with sweat.

"Don't you want to see for yourself?" Silas taunted, his good hand snatching the locket. With his other, chromed hand, he ripped the neural-jack from the table's port and fumbled to plug it into the locket.

"Let's have a look at what they took from you. Let's see what makes a ghost scream."

It happened in a fraction of a second. The click of the jack seating. The locket glowing with an internal, angry light. And the feedback.

It wasn't a sound. It was a psychic shockwave that slammed into me, bypassing the Syn-Numb, bypassing every wall I'd ever built. A firehose of pure, unadulterated sensation.

...the smell of ozone and burning chrome... the slick feel of blood under my fingernails... a woman's face, contorted in a silent scream, her eyes wide with betrayal... a board room, the faces cold and impassive... my handler, a man named Veridian, his voice calm as he says, "The asset is compromised. We need to excise the memory of the event. All of it. It's for his own good."...

The feedback hit Silas directly. His eyes rolled back in his head, and a thin line of blood trickled from his nose. But I got the splashback. The raw data. My own lost trauma. It wasn't someone else's memory. It was *mine*.

A roar tore from my throat, a sound of animal rage and pain. The world dissolved into red. The heavies were shouting, scrambling for their guns. I didn't think. I acted. The kinetic pistol bucked in my hand. A wet, percussive *thump*. One of the heavies slammed back against the wall, a neat, dark hole in his chest. The other one got a shot off, a bolt of plasma that seared the air past my ear and melted a patch of the wall behind me. *Thump*. He crumpled to the floor.

Silas was spasming on the ground, the locket still clutched in his hand, the neural-jack still plugged into his temple. He was drowning in my nightmares. I kicked him, hard, and he curled into a ball, whimpering. I ripped the locket from his grasp, tearing the jack from his temple port with a sickening squelch of bio-fluid.

I stood there, panting, the gun smoking in my hand. The smell of burnt plastic and cooked meat filled the small room. The Syn-Numb was gone, burned away by the psychic fire. I was raw. Exposed. The static was gone. In its place was the screaming. The memories I had just glimpsed were clawing at the inside of my skull, trying to stitch themselves back into the holes in my mind.

V.S. Veridian Sterling. My old boss. He wasn't hiring me to retrieve his blackmail material. He was hiring me to retrieve the evidence of what he'd done to me. He'd lost it, and now he was paying the ghost he created to bring it back home so he could bury it for good.

I stumbled out of the cove, leaving the bodies and the blood behind. No one in the main room seemed to notice or care. A little violence in a back room was just part of the ambiance. I pushed through the crowd, out the chrome door, and back into the greasy, indifferent rain of the Sump.

Back in my hab-unit. The city's neon pulse was a dull throb against my window. The fifty-thousand-cred contract was completed. The other twenty-five K was sitting in my account. Enough to disappear. Enough to buy a mountain of Syn-Numb, enough to build the static walls so high that not even my own ghosts could climb them.

The locket sat on the table in front of me. It was cool to the touch. Platinum and obsidian. An elegant prison.

My hand trembled as I reached for it.

Everything in me, every scarred neuron, every fiber of my being conditioned by years of addiction, screamed at me to make the delivery. Take the creds. Buy the Numb. Let the static come back and swallow the screams. It was the easy way. It was the safe way. It was oblivion.

But for the first time in years, the static was gone. The silence in my head was terrifying. But it was a clean silence. A real one. I could feel the edges of the holes in my memory, the phantom limbs of my own past.

My thumb found the tiny, almost invisible clasp on the side of the locket.

To open it would be to let it all in. The trauma. The truth. The man I was before they gutted me. It might save me. It would probably destroy me.

My thumb hovered over the clasp.

Click it, and my story ends.

Don't click it, and it never even began.